

married, when you become a parent, you're financially obligated to the child. But if you are unmarried when you die, your money won't automatically go to your significant other.

For instance, let's say you and your partner have lived together for years, forgoing marriage because you both failed miserably at it the first time around. Let's also say you each have grown children from those failed marriages. If you do not put in writing that your partner should receive your money and your pension when you die, the surviving children have rights to it. And if they didn't like the man or woman you lived with all those years, they can stake claims on the house you shared when you were alive, forcing him or her out.

Also, beyond cohabitation agreements, there's never been a more important time to draw up a will than when you decide to live with someone. Many couples, especially ones without children living with them, skip this important paperwork, to their detriment. In the case of traumatic decisions like whether to let your partner continue on life support in the event of an accident or illness, your decisions can be overridden by any adult children of the ailing partner. And these are the kinds of decisions that can have a dire impact on everyone's financial future. So if you want control of your money, get everything in writing: who pays for what, who keeps what in the event of a breakup, and how things are to be dealt with when you die.

Make sure you hire a good lawyer, especially if you're bringing a lot of money into the partnership or your significant other is bringing a lot of debt. Here, you may have to reveal your Secret 10, but you certainly don't have to share it. By the way, if your potential partner is carrying a lot of debt, don't live together. I mean it. Stay in your separate abodes until you see that debt diminished.

You may have heard the "urban legend" that if you live together for seven years, you are common-law married. This is a pervasive misconception and is entirely untrue. In most states there is no way to form a common-law marriage, no matter how long you live with your partner. As of 2012, only nine states—Alabama, Colorado, Kansas, Rhode Island, South Carolina, Iowa, Montana, Oklahoma, and Texas—and the District of Columbia recognize common-law marriages. Five additional states have "grandfathered" common-law marriage: In